FREE PREVIEW



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The Psychology of Hidden Intentions, Micro-Signals and Human Masks

by LEGENDCHIL

BEFORE YOU START

A 27-year-old woman moves to Lisbon. New job, new flat, no one in the city.

In her first week she meets three people: a colleague who helps her with everything, a nervous guy who turns up late to their first date, and a quiet neighbour who says only three words.

> *One of them will manipulate her for a year.*

In this preview you'll meet all three. First, you'll learn the method to work out who it is.

IN THIS PREVIEW

- **All of Chapter 1** — the three masks and the gap that gives them away, with the real Theranos case.
- **Episode 1 of Inês's story** — the first of 25. Every episode hides clues. The answer is at the end of the book.
- **What's in the full guide** — plus a code only for people who read to the end.

CHAPTER

01

The Three Masks and the Gap

In 2013, Tyler Shultz was 22 and had just joined the most talked-about company in the world: Theranos. Its founder, Elizabeth Holmes, promised hundreds of lab tests from a single drop of blood.

Investors had put almost a billion dollars into it. Its board included former US cabinet secretaries — among them Tyler's grandfather.

Everyone believed. But Tyler worked in the lab. And in the lab he saw something no one else saw: **the results didn't add up.**

This chapter is about what Tyler saw — and why so many brilliant people didn't see the same thing.

EVERYONE WEARS A MASK

Let's start with the least obvious part: masks aren't a manipulator thing. They're a human thing.

The sociologist Erving Goffman compared social life to a theatre: there's a **stage**, where we perform, and there's **backstage**, where the performance stops (Goffman, 1959). It isn't hypocrisy. It's social survival.

And lying is part of the performance — more than we think. In a study where 147 people logged every lie they told in a diary, the average was **one to two lies a day**, almost all of them small (DePaulo et al., 1996). In other words: if everyone lies a little every day, everyone wears a mask. You're not looking for *who* has a mask — you're looking for *who uses it against you*.

So the useful question is never “does this person wear a mask?”. It's: **“how far is the mask from the face?”**

THE THREE LAYERS

— **Public Mask** — what they show strangers. Polished, rehearsed. The “CV” version.

— **Social Mask** — what they show friends and colleagues. Looser, still filtered.

— **Private Face** — real fears, desires and ambitions. It only appears with time, intimacy or pressure.

FIG. 01

The 3 masks



The mask slips for microseconds. That's when you read.

Holmes's **Public Mask** was flawless: the Steve Jobs black turtleneck, the deep voice, the unblinking stare, the story of the genius who dropped out of college at 19.

Her **Social Mask** was the one she showed the powerful men on her board: attentive, loyal, admiring.

Her **Private Face** was in the lab. And that's where Tyler was.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Think you would have noticed? Probably not.

When **206 studies** on lie detection were pooled, with more than 24,000 people judging, the accuracy rate was **54%** — barely better than flipping a coin (Bond & DePaulo, 2006). Worse: we catch truths far better than lies. The brain is built to believe.

That isn't a flaw — it's what lets us live in society. But anyone who knows how to build a good mask is counting on it.

What this means for you is simple: **your gut isn't enough.** You need a method — and that method is the gap, coming up next.

Myth: "liars avoid eye contact." When 158 supposed signs of lying were reviewed, most of them — gaze included — showed a weak link or none at all with lying (DePaulo et al., 2003). There's no single gesture that gives a liar away. There are patterns.

The cabinet secretaries on the Theranos board weren't naive. They were just judging **the wrong layer**.

THE GAP IS THE SIGNAL

Don't try to guess someone's Private Face. Look for the **gap**: the distance between what a person says they are and what they repeatedly do.

Why "repeatedly"? Because people aren't consistent in general — they're consistent in their **"if… then…" patterns**: *if* they're contradicted, *then* they attack; *if* asked for details, *then* they change the subject (Mischel & Shoda, 1995). That's where the real person lives. It proves the core rule of this book: **a moment says nothing; a pattern says almost everything.**

Examples of gaps:

— **Says they value respect** — but interrupts everyone.

— **Says they're transparent** — but tenses up at simple questions.

— **Says they don't care about money** — but talks about prices in every conversation.

— **Says they're fiercely loyal** — but trashes every old friend.

At Theranos the gap was huge: the promise was "hundreds of tests on our machine"; the reality, later revealed by the Wall Street Journal, was that the machine ran only a small fraction of them. Tyler saw the gap because he looked at what repeated every day.

> *A single gap is noise. A gap that repeats is information.*

THREE MASKS TO RECOGNISE

— **The Victim Mask** — everything happens to them, nothing is ever their fault. *It asks for your empathy.*

— **The Competence Mask** — huge promises, zero detail. *It asks for your trust.*

— **The Loyalty Mask** — "you're like a brother to me" after two weeks. *It asks for access.*

Holmes wore the **Competence** mask. The tell: **the more specific your question, the vaguer the answer.**

And **Loyalty** is the most dangerous, because it turns people against whoever doubts. When Tyler told his grandfather what he was seeing, he was rebuked. His grandfather sided with Holmes.

> *People who work hard to convince you of who they are rarely are.*

THE MOMENT THE MASK SLIPS

Keeping a mask on is tiring. And when the mind is busy, control fails.

In a study with 55 police officers, asking suspects to tell their story **backwards** — a task that overloads the brain — raised lie detection from **46% to 58%** (Vrij et al., 2008). The lesson: you don't need to be a detective. You just need to notice what happens when someone's mind is busy.

In real life, three moments do the same thing:

— **Stress** — no energy left to perform.

— **Surprise** — no time to prepare the answer.

— **Frustration** — they lost, were contradicted, didn't get what they wanted.

At Theranos, that moment came when Tyler started asking questions. The company didn't answer with data. **It answered with lawyers.**

You don't need to provoke these moments. Just notice them when they happen. How someone treats the waiter who got their order wrong tells you more than ten pleasant dinners with you.

WHAT THE GAP IS NOT

— **A mask isn't a lie.** Everyone has a stage and a backstage.

— **A gap can be insecurity.** The pattern tells you *where* to look, not *why*.

— **Don't diagnose.** The goal is to decide how much access someone has earned.

HOW IT ENDED

In 2015, the Wall Street Journal exposed Theranos. Tyler was one of the sources. The company collapsed. In 2022, Holmes was convicted of fraud and later sentenced to more than 11 years in prison.

Tyler had no special gift. He did one thing: **he compared what he was told with what he saw, over and over** — and trusted the pattern, not the mask.

That's what you're going to learn to do.

But to see a gap, you first need to know what someone's *normal* is. Without that, you'll see lies where there are only nerves. That's where Chapter 2 begins.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Before you give someone new access — money, secrets, your home — pick one thing they say they are and wait for three behaviours that confirm it.
HELP SOMEONE	If someone close to you is dazzled by a new person, don't attack the mask. Ask: "And how does he react when things go wrong?"

> *Don't read the person. Read the distance between what they say and what they do.*

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Pick someone you talk to a lot. Write down three things they say about themselves. For one week, log only behaviours that confirm or contradict each one. At the end: where's the gap?

EPISODE 1 · ARRIVAL

Inês is 27 and arrived in Lisbon on a Sunday night with a car full of boxes. New job at a communications agency, a one-bedroom flat in Arroios, no friends in the city. Her four-year relationship had ended in June.

On Monday, the first person to talk to her is Sofia, from the same team. She shows her the coffee machine, lends her a phone charger, tells her where you can eat well for under ten euros. "Everyone here is nice, but there's a lot of talking behind backs. I stay out of it." At lunch, between the dish of the day and dessert, she mentions that Marco, across the open-plan office, "had a serious problem with the boss — but that stays between us." Before they pay, she asks: "And you, did you come on your own? Boyfriend back in Porto?"

On Thursday, Inês has her first date with Daniel, whom she met on an app. He'd warned her: "I'm very punctual." He arrives twenty minutes late, apologising — the metro stopped at Alameda. He talks fast, laughs at himself, looks more at his glass than at her.

The neighbour next door is called Rui. Early forties, quiet. On Friday they pass on the stairs and he asks which agency she works at. She tells him. "Ah," he says. "I know it." And he goes up.

That night, sitting on the floor among the boxes, Inês thinks Lisbon might not be so hard after all. She already has a friend.

Who would you trust?

FREE PREVIEW

Who would you trust?

Keep your answer. In the full guide, the story runs for 25 episodes — one at the end of every chapter, each testing what you've just learned. The end of the book has the answer, with every clue episode by episode. See if you get it right.

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Inside the full guide

Part I · Read	How to tell when someone's lying without falling for the myths (crossed arms mean nothing). Feet, voice, words, text messages. Reading any room in 60 seconds.
Part II · The Predators	Why they choose you. The Dark Triad. The 6 signs of love bombing. Isolation, gaslighting, triangulation — and the mechanism that stops you leaving.
Part III · Power	Cialdini's 6 triggers that make you say “yes”. Manipulation at work and in families. Real vs. fake interest. The 5 signs that come before betrayal.
Part IV · Defense	Ready-made lines for every tactic. Non-negotiable boundaries. How to leave and not go back. How to help someone who's trapped. A 7-day training protocol.

26 chapters · 25 real cases · 40+ sources · 10 illustrations · 1 mystery · 50-sign checklist

Bonus: printable 50-sign cheat sheet + the 15 red flags test.

A PEEK AT THE FINAL CHECKLIST

1. A gap between what they say they are and what they do
2. A sudden change from baseline
3. Three deviations tied to the same topic
4. Contempt — one corner of the lip
5. A mouth-only smile
6. A face that contradicts the words
7. Pressed lips
8. Feet pointing at the exit
9. Hands that disappear on a specific topic
10. A gesture that arrives after the word
11. A long pause before a simple answer
12. Too many explanations
13. "Honestly", "I swear", "why would I lie?"
14. Answering a question with a question
15. Messages that shrink and replies that take longer, for weeks
16. Accelerated intimacy

+ 40 more signs in the full guide



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